16-week STAR drill rubric: grade behavioral stories on situation depth, task ownership, action verbs, and quantified results

Computer
Handshake and Big Interview integration planner: map mock interview milestones, coach appointment workflows, and rubric tracking
Computer
Turn STAR behavioral practice into a 16-week grading rubric and student workbook
Design the Week 1-4 technical interview modules for this computer science track
Map out the Handshake and Big Interview assignment milestones across the 16 weeks

The computer-science track should use one **16-week** curriculum with two parallel strands: behavioral storytelling and technical problem-solving. Big Interview supports learning and assigned practice; Handshake supports career-center appointment workflows; Semester connects assignments, evidence, feedback, and progress.

I created three companion artifacts: a CS student workbook, a weekly integration-and-assignment planner, and a STAR rubric CSV.

One important adjustment: grade quantified results when they are defensible, but do not require numbers for full credit. Likewise, evaluate action verbs through the concrete work they describe—not verb density or polished wording.

1. STAR behavioral rubric

This proposed rubric directly covers your four requested dimensions. It is an educational rubric, not a validated hiring assessment.

Four dimensions, 100-point scale

Dimension	Weight	What the evaluator examines
Situation depth	20%	Relevant context, stakes, constraints, and enough detail to understand the challenge
Task ownership	25%	The student's specific responsibility and its distinction from the team's responsibility
Action specificity	35%	Concrete personal steps, meaningful action verbs, reasoning, tradeoffs, and collaboration
Result quality	20%	Grounded outcomes, defensible measurement, attribution, limitations, and learning

"Depth" means useful context, not a longer answer. "Ownership" does not mean the student had to lead the entire project.

Score anchors

Dimension	0 — Missing	1 — Emerging	2 — Developing	3 — Proficient	4 — Strong
Situation	No context	Vague setting	Basic context with important gaps	Clear, relevant challenge and constraints	Concise context explaining stakes and constraints
Task	No responsibility	Team goal only	Personal role partly identifiable	Clear responsibility and boundaries	Clear ownership, constraints, and distinction from team work
Action	No action	Labels such as “helped” without specifics	Some steps, little reasoning	Concrete personal steps and reasoning	Sequenced actions, tradeoffs, appropriate collaboration, and clear attribution
Result	No outcome	Vague or unsupported claim	Outcome described, basis unclear	Grounded qualitative or quantitative outcome	Grounded outcome with attribution, measurement limits, and learning

The weighted score is:

$$\text{Score} = \sum_i w_i \frac{s_i}{4}$$

Here, w_i is the dimension’s percentage weight and s_i is its 0–4 score.

A response scoring 3 in every dimension receives 75/100. Keep the four dimension scores visible rather than displaying only the total.

Action verbs: what earns credit

Weak:

> “I helped improve the application.”

Stronger:

> “I reproduced the error, traced it to the request-validation logic, added a failing test, and changed the validation path.”

The second answer earns credit for observable steps and ownership—not merely for using “traced” or “added.”

Useful verb categories include:

- Investigation: inspected, reproduced, compared, traced.
- Implementation: built, refactored, configured, documented.
- Validation: tested, measured, reviewed, checked.
- Collaboration: coordinated, explained, requested, incorporated.

Do not reward impressive verbs that exaggerate the student's role.

Quantified results: evidence rules

Result type	Example	Assessment
Supported measurement	"The median runtime decreased from X to Y using the same test inputs."	Credit the outcome and measurement basis
Supported qualitative outcome	"The regression test passed, and the team accepted the fix."	Eligible for full credit
Team-level outcome	"The team delivered the project; I owned validation and tests."	Credit with appropriate attribution
Unsupported metric	"Efficiency improved by 40%," with no basis	Ask for support or revise; do not reward the number
Unsuccessful outcome	"The approach failed because…; I changed…"	Can score highly for honest outcome analysis and learning

Claim verification stays separate from story quality. Missing evidence does not prove an experience is false.

2. Week-by-week assignments and integration milestones

The following assignment labels are proposed Semester labels—not actual Big Interview assignment codes.

Week	Student assignment and STAR drill	Big Interview milestone	Handshake / coach milestone
1	Baseline teamwork story; CS lab: pair-sum problem and tests	Fast Track foundations; baseline practice	Check school-linked Career Center access
2	Ownership story; annotate a target posting; CS lab: frequency counting	Interview Prep; begin Answer Builder	Request an initial planning or résumé review if needed
3	Problem-solving story; CS lab: balanced delimiters	Behavioral lessons; revise the story	Check request status; prepare permitted materials
4	Conflict story; debug a defect; supported technical mini-mock	Assignment A: foundation interview	Request week-8 mock early if local lead times require
5	Revise three stories to clarify personal actions and reasoning	Assignment B: action and follow-ups	Prepare two questions for the coach
6	Setback story; audit numerical claims and qualitative outcomes	Answer Builder result revisions	Request or confirm week-8 mock
7	Targeted résumé; three evidence links; project explanation	Resume Curriculum, if licensed	Share selected materials with the coach
8	Human behavioral mock; two focused retries	Pre-mock practice set	Attend mock I; record permitted feedback
9	Leadership and prioritization stories; coverage map	Assignment C: behavioral range	Review whether additional support is needed

Week	Student assignment and STAR drill	Big Interview milestone	Handshake / coach milestone
10	Employer briefing, motivation answer, interviewer questions	Interview Prep and common-question guidance	Request week-12 mock
11	Role-specific coding, debugging, or design exercises	Relevant practice set or playbook	Prepare specialist questions
12	Mixed mock; ambiguity, tradeoffs, and follow-ups	Assignment D: mixed interview	Complete mock II or approved alternative
13	Six-question simulation; revise two answers	Assignment E: full simulation	Request week-15 final mock
14	Format rehearsal; technology and accessibility checks	Relevant format lessons	Confirm final appointment
15	Final role-specific mock; résumé consistency audit	Targeted weak-area practice	Complete mock III
16	Final preparation packet; baseline comparison; next-month plan	Review submitted assignments	Optional final advising follow-up

Big Interview documents Fast Track, Written Curriculum, Resume Curriculum, and Interview Playbooks; availability and interface details must be verified for the institution's account.[1]

For actual assignments, students use their school or organization's Big Interview page, open Assignments, and enter an instructor-provided code or follow an invitation link. Codes must belong to active assignments and are not login passwords or registration codes.[2]

3. Week 1–4 technical interview modules

These are proposed beginner-to-intermediate CS modules. Offer scaffolded and extension versions based on the student's prior coursework. Let students use an appropriate language they know.

Use a consistent technical workflow:

Clarify → propose an approach → implement → test → explain complexity → reflect.

Week 1: communicate an approach and test a simple solution

Learning objectives

- Restate a problem accurately.
- Ask about ambiguous requirements.
- Describe a baseline solution.
- Write meaningful tests.
- Explain personal project experience without overstating it.

Technical assignment: pair-sum

> Given a list of integers and a target, return indices of two distinct elements whose values sum to the target, or report that no pair exists.

Student tasks:

1. Clarify whether multiple solutions are possible.
2. Explain why the same element cannot be used twice.
3. Implement a straightforward baseline.
4. Test duplicates, negative numbers, no solution, and a short input.
5. Explain time and space usage.
6. Optionally propose an improved approach.

Deliverables:

- Code or approved pseudocode.
- Tests and expected outputs.
- A short explanation.
- A reflection identifying one improvement.

STAR drill:

> “Tell me about a time you worked with others on a project.”

Require the student to distinguish the team’s goal from their own contribution.

Assessment emphasis

Grade the problem-solving process and correctness, not how quickly the student recognizes a familiar pattern.

Week 2: hash maps and ownership

Learning objectives

- Select a data structure for a stated need.
- Explain assumptions behind complexity claims.
- Separate requirements from implementation choices.
- Describe a task the student personally owned.

Technical assignment: frequency counting

> Return the frequency of each item in an input sequence. Define how case, punctuation, or normalization will be handled if the input contains text.

Student tasks:

1. State the input and output contract.
2. Choose and justify the data structure.
3. Implement the solution.
4. Test empty input, repeated values, and normalization choices.
5. Discuss time and space usage under stated assumptions.
6. Explain one alternative and why it was not selected.

STAR drill:

> “Tell me about a task you were responsible for completing.”

The Task section should identify:

- Assigned responsibility.
- Relevant constraint.
- What success meant.
- What belonged to another team member.

Week 3: stacks, tradeoffs, and technical explanations

Learning objectives

- Explain a useful invariant.
- Identify failure cases.
- Test malformed input.
- Communicate reasoning rather than narrating syntax.

Technical assignment: balanced delimiters

> Determine whether parentheses, brackets, and braces are correctly balanced and nested.

Student tasks:

1. Clarify whether other characters should be ignored.
2. Explain the proposed stack behavior.
3. Implement the checker.
4. Test empty input, unmatched closers, incomplete nesting, and mismatched pairs.

5. Explain why delimiter counts alone are insufficient.
6. Describe complexity and limitations.

STAR drill:

> "Tell me about a difficult problem you solved."

Follow-up:

> "What alternatives did you consider, and why did you choose this one?"

Week 4: debugging, code review, and supported mini-mock

Learning objectives

- Reproduce a defect before changing code.
- Distinguish a symptom from its cause.
- Add a regression test.
- Handle reviewer questions constructively.

Technical assignment

Provide a small faulty implementation from weeks 1–3, such as a pair-sum solution that incorrectly reuses the same index.

Student tasks:

1. Produce a failing example.
2. Explain the root cause.
3. Make a bounded correction.
4. Add a regression test.
5. Check that existing tests still pass.
6. Explain the fix as if presenting it in a code review.

Mini-mock:

- One clarification question.
- One implementation or debugging problem.
- One test discussion.
- One complexity question.
- One behavioral story and follow-up.

STAR drill:

> "Tell me about a disagreement or difficult feedback you received."

Do not require the story to involve a dramatic conflict. A genuine code-review disagreement is sufficient.

Shared technical rubric

Dimension	Weight
Requirements and clarification	15%
Approach and reasoning	20%
Correctness	25%
Testing and debugging	20%
Complexity explanation	10%
Communication and reflection	10%

Keep this separate from the STAR rubric. A coding solution and a behavioral story assess different work.

For Semester-native execution, use isolated runtimes, resource limits, controlled file access, and restricted network access. Record AI assistance according to the institution's learning policy.

4. Grading progression across the semester

Keep the STAR rubric stable so comparisons remain meaningful. Increase task complexity rather than quietly changing what a score means.

Period	Developmental expectation
Weeks 1–4	Identify the story components and personal responsibility
Weeks 5–8	Explain concrete actions and grounded outcomes
Weeks 9–12	Select relevant stories and answer follow-ups
Weeks 13–16	Adapt stories naturally to role-specific questions

Suggested course weighting

- Weekly behavioral drills: 20%.
- Technical assignments: 20%.
- Story bank and evidence map: 15%.
- Résumé and portfolio: 15%.
- Mock-interview milestones: 20%.
- Capstone reflection and next plan: 10%.

Baseline work should receive completion credit rather than a high-stakes performance grade.

Allow revisions and approved alternatives. Do not penalize students for institutional appointment shortages, inaccessible vendor workflows, confidential details withheld, or technical recording failures.

Automated feedback boundaries

AI may:

- Identify likely STAR passages.
- Quote evidence for each observation.
- Suggest a provisional dimension score.
- Flag unclear ownership.
- Ask for the basis of a numerical claim.
- Recommend a focused retry.

AI must not:

- Invent metrics or achievements.
- Infer deception from missing evidence.
- Grade personality, accent, gaze, or facial expressions.
- Turn private practice into employer rankings.
- issue an official grade without the authorized human assessment process.

5. Handshake coach workflow

Student workflow

1. Open Career Center → Appointments.
2. Select Schedule a New Appointment.
3. Choose the locally configured category and appointment type.
4. Select a time and appointment medium.
5. Explain the preparation goal.
6. Request the appointment.
7. Monitor its status. [3]

Suggested request:

> “I am completing the CS interview-preparation track. I would like a mock focused on personal contribution, technical project explanations, and follow-up questions. I can share my résumé and selected stories.”

Track actual states

Handshake documents Requested, Approved, Declined, and Completed in the student appointment view. Staff workflows can include additional states such as No Show and Started. [4] [5]

Semester should distinguish:

- Requested: awaiting response.
- Approved: scheduled, not yet completed.
- Completed: source reports completion.
- Student reflection submitted: separate curriculum evidence.
- Coach rubric available: separate assessment evidence.

Never infer attendance merely because the appointment date passed.

Before and after each mock

Before:

- Student previews and approves shared materials.
- Coach receives the target role and two goals.
- Student confirms format and accessibility needs.

After:

- Coach records observations using the agreed rubric.
- Student sees feedback and may correct context.
- Student chooses two revisions.
- Semester creates personal next actions only within the student's selected support settings.

If a qualified technical interviewer is unavailable, distinguish a general career-coaching session from a specialist technical evaluation.

6. Big Interview assignment administration

Instructor preparation

For each proposed assignment A–E:

1. Confirm authorized instructor or administrator access.
2. Create the assignment in the institution's account.
3. Select questions appropriate to the learning objective.
4. Configure due dates, attempts, and review expectations.
5. Establish accessible alternatives and technical-failure procedures.
6. Obtain the real assignment code or invitation.

7. Link the assignment to the matching Semester milestone.

A university faculty guide confirms that assignment creation requires appropriate access and produces a code for students; its exact navigation is institution-specific. [6]

Student participation

Students access an assignment through the institution's Big Interview account, using an invitation or an active instructor-provided code. Missing or invalid codes must be resolved with the instructor or administrator, not fabricated by Semester. [2]

Vendor completion, vendor feedback, Semester formative feedback, and the instructor's final decision should remain separate records.

7. Rubric tracking and integration data model

These are proposed logical records, not verified database tables or endpoints.

Record	Essential fields
CurriculumAssignment	Week, objective, required deliverables, alternatives, due date
VendorAssignmentLink	Vendor, tenant, verified identifier, access method, source timestamp
PracticeAttempt	Student, question, response version, approved context, assistance disclosure
RubricEvaluation	Rubric version, dimension scores, supporting quotations, reviewer, provisional/final state
AppointmentMilestone	Provider reference, reported status, timestamp, completion basis
StoryVersion	Experience, STAR content, attribution, confidentiality, student approval
EvidenceLink	Artifact, claim, permission, verification status
ReviewDecision	Human decision, rationale, student correction or appeal

Synchronization rules

- Begin with approved links and student-attested evidence when no authorized integration exists.
- Import only data explicitly permitted by institutional and vendor agreements.
- Preserve source identifiers and timestamps.
- Make updates idempotent.
- Reconcile discrepancies instead of silently overwriting them.
- Keep student-private recordings outside general institutional analytics.
- Do not publish story banks or coach notes to employers.

No connector write, appointment booking, vendor assignment creation, or deployment was performed here.

8. Student dashboard and release gates

Dashboard

Show five useful areas:

1. This week: assignment, permitted tools, and next action.
2. Story bank: coverage, ownership gaps, and approved versions.
3. Technical practice: correctness, tests, reasoning, and retries.
4. Coach appointments: actual source status and preparation tasks.
5. Rubric progress: comparable attempts using the same rubric version.

Avoid a combined “hireability” score.

Activation gates

Gate	Owner	Evidence required
Curriculum readiness	Career education lead	Reviewed assignments, grading policy, accessible alternatives
CS content readiness	CS educator	Tested exercises, reference solutions, specialist review
AI feedback readiness	AI lead and career specialists	Quotation-grounded scoring, disagreement analysis, correction path
Vendor readiness	Integration owner	Licensed access, verified assignment workflow, permitted data flow
Privacy readiness	Security/privacy lead	Tenant isolation, storage authorization, scoped sharing and revocation
Institutional activation	Implementation lead	Explicit authorization, support ownership, monitoring, rollback

This extends the existing Semester career direction—applications, preparation, skills, evidence, portfolios, and human support—while retaining the handoff requirement to audit existing implementations and prove access controls before declaring work complete. [7] [8]

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